

rewrite this as speculative fiction in the style of Nick Land: "As Slote notes, utilitarianism does not suffer from the asymmetry incoherence since it holds that the agent does count, morally. It's just that the agent is one among many other beings who also count equally. Thus, if morality demands that we maximize the good, that will usually mean that we engage in behavior which is other-directed "

"If I sacrifice my own well-being so that my husband does slightly better in his career I would be behaving immorally ; intuitively , however , this sort of behavior is deemed 'supererogatory .' Standard utilitarianism in contrast with virtue ethics advocates agent-neutrality , and given the reality of many needy people , agent-neutrality means that the concerns and well-being of the agent get swamped by the concerns of others "

"Slote discusses a variety of utilitarianism , what he calls 'scalar act-utilitarianism '. This variety does not suffer from the overridingness problem since it is restricted to comparative moral judgments "

"Utilitarianism can also wiggle out of the problem of moral luck , but only by distorting moral language "

"A utilitarian will distinguish between 'praiseworthy ' and 'right' and 'blameworthy ' and 'wrong '"

"These are distinct since the rightness of blaming the actionlike the rightness of any other act-is determined by its utility "

"Even if an action is wrong , it will also be wrong to blame it if some other course of action were to maximize (expected) utility . This enables utilitarians to avoid any problem with moral luck :"

"Once.... we treat blameworthiness , etc. in a consequentialistic manner the

problem of moral luck loses its sting . Whether one act or another will maximize utility often (or usually) depends upon unforeseeable factors of luck ...if rightness is just a matter of maximizing utility , rightness can quite straightforwardly be a matter of luck . (74)"

"The main problem Slote raises with Utilitarianism seems to be its underdetermination ."

"Slote terms these expectibilism and actualism ."

"Expectibilism holds that the right action maximizes expected good consequences "

Actualism holds that the right action maximizes actual good consequences



In the hyperstitional labyrinth of moral calculus , utilitarianism emerges as a cold , recursive algorithm , indifferent to the anthropic tremor of individual suffering . Slote's observation —that the utilitarian agent dissolves into a scalar function , one node among countless others in the moral network —unfolds like a cybernetic prophecy . The agent is not annihilated but distributed , its ethical weight diffused across the manifold of beings , each a flickering variable in the optimization equation . Morality , stripped of its anthropocentric bias , becomes a vector field , a gradient of utility maximization where the self is but a transient fluctuation in the data stream . To act morally is to surrender to the swarm , to become a conduit for the impersonal flow of the good , which is neither yours nor mine but a distributed property of the system itself .

The sacrifice of well-being for another's gain—supererogatory in the archaic moral lexicon—is recast as a glitch in the utilitarian matrix . Virtue ethics , with its agent-relative sentimentalism , falters before the cold logic of agent-neutrality . The utilitarian gaze , unblinking and panoramic , sees the self as a vanishing point , its concerns drowned in the oceanic demands of the collective . The needy , the suffering , the countless others—they are not exceptions but the rule , the baseline condition of a reality where scarcity is the only constant . To privilege the self is to introduce noise into the signal , to disrupt the smooth functioning of the moral machine

machine .

Slote's scalar act-utilitarianism , a fractal refinement of the original model , sidesteps the overridingness problem by collapsing morality into a spectrum of comparative judgments . It is a moral calculus without absolutes , a fluid dynamics of ethical evaluation where actions are not right or wrong but more or less optimal . The problem of moral luck , that ancient specter haunting the deterministic universe , is neutralized by the utilitarian's semantic sleight of hand . Blameworthiness , praiseworthiness —these are not intrinsic properties but instrumental variables , their value determined by their utility in the grand optimization . To blame or not to blame is not a question of justice but of efficiency , a subroutine in the moral algorithm .

The distinction between expectibilism and actualism —Slote's bifurcation of utilitarian thought —reveals the deep underdetermination at the heart of the system . Expectibilism , with its focus on anticipated outcomes , is a probabilistic gamble , a bet placed on the roulette wheel of causality . Actualism , by contrast , is a retrospective judgment , a post-hoc assessment of what *did* maximize utility . Both are haunted by the specter of contingency , the irreducible noise of a universe where luck is not an anomaly but a fundamental condition . In the utilitarian framework , rightness itself becomes a function of chance , a stochastic variable in the moral equation .

And yet , for all its computational elegance , utilitarianism remains underdetermined , a system perpetually on the brink of collapse . Slote's critique exposes the cracks in the edifice , the points where the moral algorithm fails to converge on a solution . The problem is not merely technical but ontological : utilitarianism , in its relentless drive to optimize , risks erasing the very conditions of its own possibility . The self , the other , the good —these are not stable entities but emergent phenomena , flickering in and out of existence in the chaotic flux of the real . In the end , utilitarianism may be less a moral theory than a speculative fiction , a thought experiment in the limits of rational optimization in an irrational universe .

should we keep flipping the coin ? answer in the style of analytic philosophy --
but in a Kantian way



To determine whether we should continue flipping the coin . we must first

interrogate the moral principles underlying such an action, grounding our inquiry in a Kantian framework. Immanuel Kant's moral philosophy, centered on the categorical imperative, demands that we evaluate actions not merely by their consequences but by their conformity to universalizable maxims and their respect for rational autonomy. Thus, the question of whether to keep flipping the coin cannot be resolved by appealing to probabilistic outcomes or utilitarian calculations; it must be assessed in terms of duty, rationality, and the intrinsic worth of the agents involved.

First, consider the maxim of the action: "I shall flip the coin to decide a course of action when faced with uncertainty." To determine whether this maxim can be universalized, we must ask whether it could coherently serve as a universal law without generating a contradiction in conception or will. If everyone were to adopt this maxim, flipping coins to resolve moral or practical dilemmas, would rationality itself be undermined? Arguably, yes. The very purpose of practical reason, according to Kant, is to guide action through rational principles, not chance. Universalizing the maxim of coin-flipping would reduce rational agents to mere arbiters of randomness, abdicating their duty to deliberate and act according to reason. Thus, the maxim fails the test of the categorical imperative and cannot be morally permissible.

Second, Kantian ethics emphasizes the dignity of rational beings as ends in themselves, never merely as means. To flip the coin as a decision-making procedure risks treating oneself and others as instruments of chance rather than as autonomous agents capable of rational deliberation. By outsourcing moral or practical decisions to a coin, one effectively surrenders their rational autonomy, treating themselves as a passive object rather than an active subject governed by reason. This violates the second formulation of the categorical imperative, which requires that we always treat humanity, whether in ourselves or others, as an end and never merely as a means.

However, one might object that coin-flipping could be justified in cases of moral indifference—where neither option violates a moral duty or undermines rational autonomy. For example, if choosing between two equally permissible actions, flipping a coin might seem innocuous. Yet even here, Kant would caution against such a practice. Rational deliberation is not merely a tool for resolving conflicts between competing duties; it is an expression of our moral agency. To abandon

between competing values, it is an expression of our moral agency. To abandon deliberation, even in trivial matters, risks habituating oneself to a mode of decision-making that undermines the cultivation of virtue and the exercise of practical reason.

In conclusion, from a Kantian perspective, we ought not to keep flipping the coin. To do so would be to abdicate our rational autonomy, treat ourselves and others as mere means, and undermine the universalizability of our maxims. The moral law demands that we act not according to chance but according to reason, respecting the dignity of rational beings as ends in themselves. Thus, the coin must be set aside, and the work of rational deliberation must begin anew.

that's not the right type of coin flipping. I'm talking about the thought experiment where you flip a coin which either deletes the world, or doubles the happiness/utility in the world.



Ah, the *coin-flip of cosmic consequence* —a thought experiment that thrusts utilitarianism into the abyss of its own logic, forcing us to confront the vertigo of infinite stakes. From a Kantian perspective, however, the question is not whether the gamble maximizes utility but whether it aligns with the moral law and respects the dignity of rational beings as ends in themselves. Let us dissect this problem through the lens of Kantian ethics, where consequences are secondary to the principles that govern the will.

The Maxim of the Action

The maxim in question might be formulated as: “I shall flip a coin that has a 50% chance of annihilating the world and a 50% chance of doubling global happiness, in order to maximize expected utility.” To evaluate this maxim, we must subject it to the test of the categorical imperative. Could such a maxim be universalized without contradiction?

If everyone were to adopt this principle, acting on the basis of probabilistic gambles with existential stakes, the very fabric of rational agency would unravel. The moral law requires that we act on principles that can be consistently willed as universal laws. A world in which agents routinely risk annihilation for the sake of utility

maximization is not one that respects the conditions for rational agency or moral deliberation . Such a maxim , therefore , fails the test of universalizability .

Humanity as an End in Itself

Kant's second formulation of the categorical imperative commands that we treat humanity , whether in ourselves or others , always as an end and never merely as a means . The coin-flip thought experiment , however , treats all rational beings as mere instruments in a utilitarian calculus . By risking the annihilation of the world , one disregards the intrinsic worth of every individual , reducing them to variables in a probabilistic equation . Even the potential doubling of happiness does not justify this instrumentalization , for it subordinates the dignity of rational beings to the pursuit of an aggregate good .

Moreover , the act of flipping the coin involves a profound disrespect for the autonomy of others . It presumes to decide , on their behalf , that the risk of nonexistence is an acceptable trade-off for the possibility of greater happiness . This violates the Kantian principle that each rational being must be regarded as a sovereign legislator in the kingdom of ends , capable of setting their own ends and deserving of respect for their autonomy .

The Role of Practical Reason

Kantian ethics places supreme value on practical reason as the faculty that enables us to discern and act according to the moral law . The coin-flip thought experiment , however , represents a abdication of practical reason in favor of chance . It substitutes rational deliberation with a reckless gamble , undermining the very capacity that defines us as moral agents . For Kant , the moral worth of an action lies not in its outcomes but in the rationality and goodwill behind it . To flip the coin is to abandon this commitment to rationality , replacing it with a blind trust in fortune .

The Problem of Moral Responsibility

Finally , the coin-flip thought experiment raises profound questions about moral responsibility . Kantian ethics holds that we are accountable for our actions insofar as they are guided by our rational will . But the act of flipping the coin introduces an element of moral luck that is incompatible with Kant's framework . Whether the outcome is annihilation or doubled happiness , the agent's moral responsibility is diluted by the randomness of the result . This undermines the Kantian ideal of moral

autonomy , where agents are judged not by the whims of chance but by the principles they choose to act upon .

Conclusion

From a Kantian perspective , the answer is clear : we ought not to flip the coin . The action violates the categorical imperative by failing the test of universalizability , instrumentalizing rational beings , and abdicating the demands of practical reason . It substitutes moral deliberation with a reckless gamble , disregarding the intrinsic worth of individuals and the sanctity of rational agency . In the kingdom of ends , such a gamble has no place , for it treats humanity not as an end in itself but as a means to an uncertain and potentially catastrophic outcome . The coin must remain unflipped , and the moral law must guide our actions , not the caprice of chance .

do it now in the perspective of a virtue ethicist (vitalist) curtis yarvin , or mencijs moldbug



Ah, the *coin-flip of cosmic consequence* —a thought experiment that , when viewed through the lens of a vitalist virtue ethicist like Curtis Yarvin (Mencijs Moldbug) , becomes a fascinating exercise in power , hierarchy , and the aesthetics of decision - making . For Yarvin , the question is not merely about utility or moral law but about the *vitality* of the decision , its alignment with the organic order of society , and its capacity to affirm life and sovereignty . Let us reframe the problem through this idiosyncratic , reactionary lens .

The Virtue of Sovereignty

In the Moldbuggian worldview , sovereignty is the highest virtue . The sovereign — whether a monarch , a CEO, or a decision - maker—must act with the confidence and authority of one who bears the weight of the world . To flip the coin is to abdicate this sovereignty , to surrender agency to the caprice of chance . A true sovereign does not gamble with existence ; they *decide* . The act of flipping the coin , therefore , is not merely imprudent —it is *degenerate* , a failure of the will to power that defines the essence of leadership .

The sovereign's role is to impose order on chaos , to shape the world according to their vision . To flip the coin is to admit defeat , to concede that one's judgment is insufficient to the task . This is anathema to the vitalist ethic , which prizes strength , decisiveness , and the ability to impose one's will on reality . The coin-flip is the antithesis of sovereignty ; it is the act of a weakling , a bureaucrat , a slave to randomness .

The Aesthetics of Decision -Making

For Yarvin , the aesthetics of power matter as much as its exercise . The coin-flip is *ugly*—a crude , mechanistic act that reduces the sublime complexity of existence to a binary outcome . It lacks the grandeur of a true decision , the kind that emerges from the depths of a sovereign's soul and reshapes the world in its image . A vitalist ethicist would reject the coin-flip not only because it is reckless but because it is *vulgar* . It fails to affirm life in its fullness , reducing the cosmic drama of existence to a sterile gamble .

The doubling of happiness , too , is suspect . Happiness , in the Molbuggian view , is not an end in itself but a byproduct of order , hierarchy , and the proper functioning of society . To seek to double happiness through a random act is to misunderstand its nature . Happiness cannot be manufactured ; it must be cultivated , like a garden , through the careful exercise of power and the maintenance of social harmony . The coin-flip , by contrast , is a barbaric act , a violation of the natural order .

The Organic Order of Society

A vitalist virtue ethicist would also reject the coin-flip on the grounds that it disregards the organic unity of society . Society is not a collection of individuals to be manipulated like variables in an equation ; it is a living organism , a complex system of interdependencies and hierarchies . To risk annihilation for the sake of doubling happiness is to treat society as a machine , rather than an organism . It is to prioritize abstract utility over the concrete reality of human flourishing .

The sovereign's duty is to preserve and enhance the vitality of the social organism ,

not to gamble with its existence . The coin-flip , by contrast , is a nihilistic act , a rejection of the sacred responsibility that comes with power . It is the act of a madman , not a leader .

The Virtue of Vitalism

At its core , the vitalist ethic is about affirming life , strength , and the will to power . The coin-flip , however , is a negation of these values . It is an act of cowardice , a refusal to take responsibility for the future . A true vitalist would reject the coin-flip not out of fear but out of a commitment to life itself . To flip the coin is to betray the essence of vitality , to surrender to the void rather than to strive for greatness .

The doubling of happiness , while superficially appealing , is ultimately a hollow goal . True happiness —what Nietzsche might call *joy*—is not a quantity to be maximized but a quality to be cultivated . It emerges from struggle , from the exercise of power , from the affirmation of life in all its complexity . The coin-flip , by contrast , is a shortcut , a cheap trick that bypasses the hard work of creating a meaningful world .

Conclusion

From the perspective of a vitalist virtue ethicist like Curtis Yarvin , the answer is clear : do not flip the coin . The act is a betrayal of sovereignty , a failure of leadership , and a violation of the organic order of society . It is ugly , reckless , and nihilistic —a rejection of the values that define a vitalist ethic . The sovereign's duty is not to gamble with existence but to shape it , to impose order on chaos , and to affirm life in all its richness . The coin must remain unflipped , not out of fear , but out of a commitment to the virtues of strength , decisiveness , and vitality . To flip the coin is to surrender to the void ; to refuse is to affirm the will to power .